

Ode to Immortality

THE STATESMAN

You don't need to wear a pair of jeans, bare your chest, gel your hair, be gizmo savvy and carry plastic money to be heroes. Neelanjana Gautam salutes the real winners



**Phalguni
Chattopadhyaya**



Sanjit Das



Gayatri Mishra

"If I am not for myself, who will be for me? If I am only for myself, who am I? If not now, when?"

WHAT lies beneath this classical dilemma is a million-dollar question. Confronting this conflict of nature is a test you and I are put through almost every day. Satanic components are obscuring the fabric of modern times. The downpour of yuppie culture has inundated us. Flaunting a devil-may-care attitude, today's youngsters constitute a garish bunch of non-entities, a reckless crop, their societal orientation notwithstanding. They couldn't care less with a gelled hairdo, gizmo savvy accessories, plastic money, fluorescent apparels and a non-stop accentuated lingo. The generation X considers them as the ultimate role model, forgetting that the world it has inherited is also the world it'll leave behind. No wonder, this forgetfulness manifests itself in a such gory way. To them a woman is just an object of lust and desire — catching them at the slightest pretext is their motto. Teasing women has become a way of life with these aimless caricatures representing generation fiasco.

But all is not lost despite the ruckus created by self-indulgence. There are men who thrive on the oft-repeated expletives, honesty, kindness, compassion, respect, responsibility, obedience and duty. And they emerge as the real winners in life. For, no one has the opulence of having no belief, for believing in nothing is also a belief in itself.

In the face of sharp polaristic odds, up goes the roar, every character count. Refashioning a generation is not an uphill task, given the potential it has to make a difference.

In this plagiaristic orgy of fractious culture connotation the likes of Bapi Sen can be an inspiring role model. The bravado exhibited by Sergeant Sen shatters the myth that you have to be a larger-than-life character. On the east coast,

Gayatri Mishra too the rare breed of people whose sense of selflessness and courage lead by example. Awards may not be the ultimate bait for people to take up the baton. Instead, it's the mark of fellow human beings that matters. Thus BDA Limited makes it an annual ritual to salute the unsung heroes of our times. Felicitations fall only upon those who carry it off with élan. The 2003 Officers' Choice Gallantry Awards tallying Rs 1,20,000 will be bestowed on these fiery, gritty souls "who have shown exemplary courage in saving others' life", says Ashoke Mukherjee, Assistant Vice-President, Marketing and Corporate Communications, BDA Limited. The company will confer a special posthumous honour on Bapi Sen. On New Year's eve this 34-year-old off-duty sergeant came to the rescue of an till now unknown woman, who was being harassed by a group of off-duty cops. He laid down his life, defending the honour of a woman. Death be not proud.

The award was instituted in 1998-99. And this year the jury has on its bench filmmaker Aparna Sen, educationist Bharati Ray, magician PC Sorcar, Jr, artist Ramananda Bandopadhyaya. The razzle-dazzle of a liquor label might pose a frivolous impression to a layman but those haven't flinched the authority from its noble footing. They will continue to shower glories on Falgunis, and Sanjits, and the ones who stake their lives even if they haven't nothing at stake for themselves. Falguni was run over by a train to save the lives of two children playing on the tracks. Sanjit was shot dead on a packed private bus for trying to stop hooligans from harassing a woman. Gayatri displayed exemplary courage when attacked by a hoodlum in a desolate city area. These off-screen heroes are no less than the lone soldier fighting on the border. One still hears such magnanimous display of chivalry and gallantry in day-to-day incidents, which escape public attention. These